

Text 1: The Paradox of Digital Communication

Proponents of digital communication hail its ability to connect people across vast distances, framing it as an unambiguous good. However, this perspective often ignores a central paradox: the very tools designed to enhance connection can simultaneously foster isolation. Mediated communication, stripped of the rich, analog data of body language, tone, and shared physical space, is a lean medium. It necessitates a compensatory performance of self, where individuals craft messages, edit responses, and curate personas. This performance, while offering a sense of control, creates a psychological distance between the performed identity and the authentic self. Furthermore, the constant, low-stakes connection to a broad network can dilute the depth of our attention, making us less available for the high-stakes, unedited intimacy of proximate relationships. Thus, we risk becoming a society of globally connected strangers, proficient in broadcasting but deficient in presence.

Questions:

1. **Tone and Perspective:** How does the author's perspective on digital communication differ from its "proponents"?
2. **Analysis of Argument:** What is the "paradox" the author identifies, and what two key reasons do they give to support its existence?
3. **Vocabulary in Context:** What is meant by "lean medium" in this context? What is it "lean" in?
4. **Inference:** What does the phrase "globally connected strangers" suggest about the quality of online relationships compared to real-world ones?
5. **Critical Evaluation:** Do you agree with the author's conclusion? Write a short paragraph (4-5 sentences) either supporting or challenging the author's view, using your own reasoning.

Text 2: The New Puppy

Maria's family finally got a new puppy. They named him Buster. He was a small, fluffy golden retriever with big, clumsy paws. On his first day, Buster was shy and hid under the sofa. But by the next morning, he was chasing his tail in the middle of the living room and chewing on Maria's slippers. Maria didn't mind. She was just happy to have a new friend.

Questions:

1. What kind of dog is Buster?
2. Where did Buster hide on his first day?
3. What two things was Buster doing the next morning?
4. How did Maria feel about her chewed slippers?
5. **Inference:** Do you think Buster was becoming more comfortable in his new home? Why or why not?

Text 3: The Value of Failure

Society often stigmatizes failure, viewing it as a setback to be avoided at all costs. Yet, many innovators and thinkers reframe failure as a necessary stepping stone to success. Failure provides invaluable data on what does not work, forcing a re-evaluation of methods and assumptions. It builds resilience, teaching perseverance in the face of adversity. The process of overcoming a failed attempt often yields more profound learning than an easy, uncomplicated success. While unpleasant in the moment, failure can be a powerful catalyst for growth, creativity, and ultimately, greater achievement.

Questions:

1. **Main Idea:** What is the central argument of this passage?
2. **Inference:** Based on the passage, how might a successful person view their past failures?
3. **Vocabulary in Context:** What is the meaning of "resilience" as used in the text?
4. **Analysis:** How does the author contrast society's view of failure with the view of "innovators and thinkers"?
5. **Application:** If a student fails an important exam, what are two positive ways, suggested by the passage, that they could respond to this failure?

Text 4: The Urban Green Spaces

Metropolitan areas are often characterized by concrete jungles and relentless noise. In the midst of this, urban parks and community gardens serve as vital oases. These green spaces are not merely aesthetic luxuries; they are crucial for public health and environmental sustainability. They offer residents a place for recreation and mental repose, reducing stress and encouraging physical activity. Furthermore, they mitigate the "urban heat island" effect, improve air quality, and support local biodiversity. The fight to preserve and expand these areas is, therefore, a fight for the very livability of our cities.

Questions:

1. **Literal Comprehension:** What two examples of "urban green spaces" are given?
2. **Inference:** Why does the author refer to these spaces as "vital oases"?
3. **Author's Purpose:** The author most likely wrote this passage to:
 - a) Describe the history of city planning.
 - b) Explain the benefits of urban green spaces and argue for their importance.
 - c) Entertain with a story about a city park.
 - d) Criticize people for not using parks enough.
4. **Vocabulary in Context:** What does "mitigate" mean in the sentence, "They mitigate the 'urban heat island' effect"?
 - a) To make worse
 - b) To measure carefully
 - c) To make less severe
 - d) To ignore completely
5. **Tone:** Identify one word or phrase from the passage that reveals the author's positive attitude toward green spaces.

Text 5 : The Gig Economy

The gig economy, characterized by short-term contracts and freelance work as opposed to permanent jobs, is reshaping the modern workforce. Platforms for ride-sharing, food delivery, and freelance coding offer unprecedented flexibility and autonomy. Workers can choose their hours and be their own bosses. However, this freedom comes with significant trade-offs. Gig workers often lack traditional employment benefits like health insurance, paid leave, and retirement plans. Income can be unpredictable, and job security is non-existent. This economic shift presents a complex paradox: liberation from the 9-to-5 grind at the potential cost of financial stability.

Questions:

1. **Main Idea:** Which sentence best captures the two-sided nature of the gig economy presented in the text?
2. **Inference:** What kind of person might be best suited for gig economy work, based on the passage?
3. **Analysis of Argument:** What is the "paradox" the author mentions in the final sentence?
4. **Vocabulary in Context:** What is a "trade-off"?
5. **Application:** If you were considering freelance work, what are two questions you should ask yourself based on the potential drawbacks listed in the passage?